

And You're Saying There's **NO MONEY** in the FOSS Business?



Strange... because we've captured the story of DeepRoot Linux, which speaks otherwise.

*H*e is a developer like you, loves GNU/Linux, but his passion didn't stop there. He decided to work full-time on free and open source software. He scouted around for like-minded people and translated their combined passion into developing products and services around open source. Meet Abhas Abhinav, who, in August 2000, founded DeepRoot Linux, a Bangalore-based GNU/Linux free software business, to quench his passion to work on free and open source software (FOSS) and to develop an entire ecosystem of products, solutions and support around FOSS.

"When we were about to start, although a whole ecosystem of open source software was available, good software alone didn't result in people adopting FOSS in their daily lives. We saw a gap between existing great software and people being able to use it. There was a need for products, solutions and support around FOSS, for people to adopt it. This need became the purpose of DeepRoot's existence," says Abhas. With a small team of three employees, Abhas started DeepRoot right after his graduation, as he already had some part-time experience in consulting for ISPs and Web service providers.

Taking off

Initially, DeepRoot Linux focused on providing network-attached storage solutions that were approximately 25 times cheaper than its competitors. Later, they shifted focus to DeepOfix, DeepRoot's office server product, which was shipped along with the hardware and fulfilled office requirements.

Stormy weather

Like any other start-up, DeepRoot Linux too faced a lot of initial turbulence. There were problems in getting funds for product development, in forming the team, and in striking the first few deals.

Financial hiccups: A story of wrong priorities

Initially, DeepRoot Linux had poor sales and cash flows, too, weren't positive. The firm had no venture capital funding. Further, the team made the mistake of focusing on product development over services around Linux. Product development demanded more funds and time; besides, the product was dependant on support services for its success. This added to the firm's financial woes, as